Dust of Snow

The big idea

Dust of Snow by the American poet **Robert Frost** shows how a tiny, ordinary moment in nature can lift a sad mood. A crow shakes snow onto the poet, and his gloomy day is saved.

What happens in the poem

- The poet is standing under a **hemlock tree** in a sad, regretful mood.
- A **crow** sitting on the tree shakes down some **dust of snow** (fine particles of snow) on him.
- This small, unexpected moment changes his **mood** — it gives his heart a change and saves **some part of a day he had rued** (regretted).

The poem has only **two stanzas of four lines** and is written as **one single sentence**, which matches the quick, single moment it describes.

Symbols and their meaning

Symbol	Usual meaning	In the poem
Crow	bad luck, sorrow, ill omen	brings joy instead
Hemlock tree	poisonous plant, death, sadness	the source of the cheering snow
Dust of snow	cold, winter	freshness, purity, sudden joy

THE IRONY

Frost uses two usually **negative** symbols — the crow and the poisonous hemlock — to bring about a **positive** change. Happiness can come from the most unlikely places.

Poetic devices

- **Rhyme scheme:** abab cdcd (crow/snow, tree/me; heart/part, mood/rued).
- **Alliteration:** "**h**as **g**iven **m**y **h**eart" → "has ... heart"; "**s**aved **s**ome part".
- **Symbolism:** crow, hemlock, snow.
- **Enjambment:** the sentence runs on across lines.
- **Imagery:** visual image of snow falling from a tree.
- Simple, conversational language; **"rued"** means regretted.

THE POET'S MOOD

The poem does not say exactly why the poet was sad. Do not invent a reason; write that he was in a **depressed, regretful** mood.

Message and value points

- Small moments in nature can heal and change our outlook.
- We should not let one bad moment ruin the whole day.
- Joy can come from unexpected, even "unlucky", sources.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

What is a "dust of snow"? How did it change the poet's mood? Why does Frost use a crow and a hemlock rather than a sparrow and a rose? What is the rhyme scheme? Write the theme in two lines.

Quick recap

- Poet: Robert Frost. Crow shakes snow from a hemlock tree onto him.
- Mood changes from regret to cheer; part of the day saved.
- Negative symbols (crow, hemlock) bring positive change.
- abab cdcd; one sentence; alliteration and symbolism.

Practice questions

1. Who wrote "Dust of Snow"?
   (a) Carl Sandburg (b) Robert Frost (c) W.B. Yeats (d) Leslie Norris
2. What does "rued" mean?
   (a) Enjoyed (b) Forgotten (c) Regretted (d) Wasted
3. On which tree was the crow sitting?
   (a) Oak (b) Pine (c) Hemlock (d) Maple
4. What does the crow usually symbolise?
   (a) Bad omen or sorrow (b) Peace (c) Wealth (d) Wisdom
5. The rhyme scheme of the poem is
   (a) aabb ccdd (b) abba cddc (c) abab cdcd (d) free verse
6. What is the main message of the poem?
   (a) Winters are harsh (b) Crows are harmful (c) Hemlock trees should be cut (d) Small moments in nature can change our mood
7. Why do you think Frost chose a crow and a hemlock tree rather than a more pleasant bird and tree?

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. c 4. a 5. c 6. d 7. see notes